Employment Guarantee Act (NREGA)—had been projected as reflecting the vision of Rahul and Sonia Gandhi. Rahul, in fact, had led a Congress delegation to the prime minister in 2007 to have the scheme extended to the entire country. Within two days, the government followed Rahul's wishes at an additional cost of Rs 8000 crore. Rahul had also fully backed the Rs 60,000 crore farm loan waiver scheme that was introduced in the 2008–09 Union budget. NREGA and farm loan waiver—Congressmen were convinced these were the twin planks that had propelled them back to power.

The truth is, the Congress actually performed much better in urban, rather than rural, India in the 2009 elections. The UPA alliance swept to power in every major metropolis, except Bangalore. The alliance won around 130 of the 200 seats which could be seen to have an 'urban character'. It was the urban middle class which was the backbone of the UPA's electoral growth, yet Congress strategists convinced themselves that their rise was in the countryside.

Rahul Gandhi, too, was convinced of the Congress's rediscovery of rural India. In October 2009, he again met some of us (again, need I say, an interaction that was off the record) to expand on his political theories. Invoking his grandmother, he said, 'Indiraji taught us this in the 1970s with her *Garibi Hatao* slogan. The core Congress vote lies amongst the poor and marginalized, among farmers, Dalits and tribals. That vote is our strength. We need to preserve it and then get an incremental vote amongst other sections. Once we do that, we will be unbeatable.'

There was a second argument he made that day. 'All of you see this as a victory of an alliance. I see it differently. I believe that the Congress party has to strengthen itself. Our future is not in alliances, it is in making the Congress party the dominant force of Indian politics once again,' he said emphatically. I tried to point out how the Congress was still in no position to call the shots without allies in key states like Bihar, UP, Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Maharashtra. 'The problem with political journalists is that you think short term. I prefer to have a long-term vision!' was his sharp response. We realized it wasn't easy winning an argument with a leader